



# Building & Validating Personas

Week 1 • Day 3 • Customer-Centric Foundations

Technical Product Manager Academy



## Day 3 Objectives

- Distinguish **behavioral personas** from demographic stereotypes
- Construct a persona from a mix of observed, reported, and inferred evidence
- Run a **5-question validation** interview — and notice when you're leading the witness
- Stress-test a persona against its own **Jobs to Be Done**
- Decide when AI is safe for persona drafting vs dangerous



# Today's Shape

| Clock         | Block                           | Outcome                               |
|---------------|---------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| 09:00 – 09:15 | Opening                         | Review PR/FAQ quotes → persona inputs |
| 09:15 – 10:30 | Block 1 + Activity 1            | Behavioral vs demographic             |
| 10:45 – 12:00 | Block 2 + Activity 2            | Build a persona from evidence         |
| 13:00 – 14:15 | Block 3 + Activity 3            | Validation interviews                 |
| 14:30 – 16:00 | Block 4 + Activity 4 + Readouts | JTBD stress-test + revision           |

# Block 1 — Behavioral vs Demographic

Why most personas don't change any decisions

# The Persona That Doesn't Do Anything

## Marketing Mary — 38, CMO, urban, drinks lattes

Job: CMO · Age: 38 · Income: \$150k · Hobbies: yoga

Mary wants to grow her business and loves data-driven insights. She's busy and values efficiency.

**What decision does this persona change?** None. It describes a stock character, not a customer. You could swap Mary for any persona and build the same product.



# The Persona That Does

## Dispatcher who hates re-routing

Role: Lead Dispatcher, 50–200 tech HVAC co. · Tenure: 10+ yrs in trades

- **Observed:** Spends 45 min post-close reconciling tickets on paper (6 of 8 dispatchers observed)
- **Observed:** Never uses keyboard shortcuts; refuses training that runs past 20 min
- **Reported:** "Mid-day re-routes are my worst hour" (7 of 10 interviewed)
- **Inferred:** Distrusts software that "hides" truck inventory behind a click

This persona changes decisions: no training longer than 20 min, inventory visible on primary screen, re-route flow is the hero path.



# Components of a Working Persona



## Always include

- Role + context (company type, size, tenure)
- Observed behaviors (not beliefs)
- Goals expressed in their words
- Current workarounds and tools
- Constraints (physical, organizational, cognitive)
- Evidence tier per claim



## Usually skip

- Stock photo + invented name (if it distracts)
- Hobbies, lifestyle, brand preferences (unless load-bearing)
- Traits written as adjectives ("busy," "tech-savvy")
- Any claim you can't tie to evidence

# Activity 1 — Persona Triage

Triads • 30 minutes

Your triad gets 3 real-world personas (sanitized from actual companies). For each:

- Highlight every claim that's behavioral vs demographic vs adjectival
- Mark which claims would change a product decision
- Rewrite the weakest one in 10 minutes

 5 min read • 15 min mark up • 10 min rewrite

# Block 2 — Build From Evidence

The Persona Validation Canvas



# The Canvas (one sheet, six boxes)

| Box                     | Content                            | Evidence tiers allowed  |
|-------------------------|------------------------------------|-------------------------|
| Role & context          | Who they are and where they work   | Observed, Reported      |
| Goals (in their words)  | What they're trying to accomplish  | Reported primarily      |
| Current behavior        | What they do today                 | Observed primarily      |
| Constraints             | What limits them                   | Observed or Reported    |
| Pain points             | What hurts (verbs, not categories) | Observed or Reported    |
| Assumptions to validate | What you don't know yet            | Inferred + AI-generated |

**Rule:** AI-generated claims can seed Boxes 1–5 but must move to a higher tier before Friday's readout.



# Using AI Safely for Persona Drafting

Role: Research assistant helping a TPM build an evidence-grounded persona.

Context:

- The user role is Lead Dispatcher at a 50-200 tech HVAC company.
- Observed behaviors (tier: Observed): [paste notes from ride-along]
- Reported statements (tier: Reported): [paste 6 interview quotes]

Constraints:

- Do NOT invent behaviors or quotes.
- Every claim in your output must cite one of the notes or quotes above, OR be flagged as Inferred.
- If you generate any claim not grounded in the inputs, tag it AI-generated with a note: "validate before use."

Format: Persona Validation Canvas (6 sections).

## Activity 2 — Build Your Persona

Triads • 45 minutes

Your triad has PR/FAQ customer quote + whatever assumptions you're carrying. Build a canvas-format persona for the primary customer in your product idea.

- Start with what you actually know (provided research packet for FieldPulse)
- Use AI only for Boxes 5 and 6 — and tag carefully
- Circle the 3 claims you'd most want to validate with a real person



10 min plan • 25 min draft • 10 min mark validation targets

# Block 3 — Validation Interviews

Getting to evidence without leading the witness



# The Five-Question Validation Protocol

1. **Walk me through the last time you did X.** (Past behavior > hypothetical)
2. **What was hardest about that?** (Let them name the pain)
3. **What did you do to work around it?** (Workarounds reveal severity)
4. **How often does that happen?** (Frequency calibrates impact)
5. **If you could wave a wand, what would change?** (Only at the end, and discount heavily)

**Do not ask:** "Would you use a product that did X?" The answer is always yes. Observe past behavior instead.



## Bias Traps in the Room

| Bias             | What it sounds like           | Correction                                              |
|------------------|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| Leading question | "Wouldn't it be great if...?" | Rephrase to past-tense behavior                         |
| Confirmation     | Only listening for "yes"      | Write down the 3 things that didn't fit your hypothesis |
| Single-story     | N=1 generalized to a persona  | Require 3+ interviews before claims                     |
| Enthusiasm       | "They loved it!"              | Count compliments vs purchase/use signals               |

## Activity 3 — Role-Play Interviews

Triads (rotating roles) • 45 minutes

Each triad member takes a turn in all three roles: **interviewer**, **interviewee** (given a FieldPulse dispatcher character card), **observer** (tallies bias traps).

- 10 min per rotation: 7 min interview + 3 min debrief
- Observer uses a provided tally sheet (leading, confirmation, enthusiasm)
- After three rounds: which validation target did *not* survive contact?



30 min rotations · 15 min synthesize

# Block 4 — JTBD Stress-Test

Does this persona explain why they'd hire (or fire) your product?



# Jobs to Be Done, Briefly

A **Job to Be Done** is the progress a customer is trying to make in a particular circumstance. Products are "hired" to make that progress and "fired" when something better comes along.

Form: *"When I [circumstance], I want to [motivation], so I can [expected outcome]."*

**Example:** "When a tech calls out sick mid-shift, I want to re-route the remaining jobs without re-keying them, so I can keep promised ETAs without staying late."



# The Stress-Test Checklist

1. For each JTBD, can the persona produce a concrete last-time-this-happened story?
2. Does the persona's current behavior explain what they "hire" today (even if it's a paper notebook)?
3. If your product didn't exist, what would they do instead? Is that a credible fallback?
4. What would have to be true for them to *fire* your product?

If the persona survives all four, you have something to engineer against. If not, you have an interview plan.

# Activity 4 — JTBD Cross-Examination

Paired triads • 60 minutes • Readouts

Triads pair. Each presents their persona + 2 JTBDs. The other triad plays "skeptical engineer" and runs the stress-test checklist out loud.

- Every "I don't know" goes on a parking lot of open validation questions
- Revise the persona to downgrade or remove unsupported claims
- 60-second readout: one claim we upgraded, one we had to drop

 25 min per direction • 10 min full-room readouts



# Day 3 Wrap

## What we built

- An evidence-tagged persona per triad
- A validation interview protocol we can rerun anytime
- A JTBD-based stress-test for personas

## What opens tomorrow

- **Pain points** — we take the persona's "pains" box and turn it into a ranked, scored map
- Your validated persona is the input

**Bring to Day 4:** Your persona sheet + at least 5 candidate pain points extracted from it.

# Questions & Reflection

What's the one assumption you're leaving the day without having validated?